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Uthra Rajgopal

Venice during the Biennale operates at a near-impossible tempo. Days begin early with the forced patience of long *vaporetto* (water taxi) queues, and end long after sunset, feet heavy from miles of cobbled streets and the rhythmic ascent of stone bridges.

While few arrive intending to consume 15 or 20 exhibitions in a single day, the city quietly compels it. Time undergoes a strange compression; the urgency to absorb everything, from the national pavilions to the numerous collateral events and the conversations spilling into canal-side bars, creates a frenetic intellectual pressure.

Yet, Venice possesses an ancient alchemy that softens this frenzy. It is the light – aqueous and translucent – that washes over faded facades, sharpening the architectural details of Venetian Gothic archways and marble columns, while muting colour into a sophisticated palette. Even the act of rushing becomes a choreographed movement through beauty.

Against this backdrop, Cameroonian-Swiss curator Koyo Kouoh’s posthumously realised exhibition *In Minor Keys* unfolds as both memorial and mediation on fracture, displacement and collective unease. (She passed away at 57 last year, at the height of her career, after a cancer diagnosis.) In this sense, given the state of the world we live in, this Biennale feels historic and important.

“There is no other place like Venice,” British visual artist Rebecca Chesney tells me. “What really stood out for me was seeing so many women artists being represented, and discovering new ones. The use of materials such as ceramics and textiles was so visible and unexpected. I cried in *Elegy*, an exhibition by artist Gabrielle Goliath, which was meant to be the South African pavilion but wasn’t due to disputes over its inclusion of a Palestinian poet.”

Honouring Kouoh

The heartbeat of this year’s Biennale is undoubtedly the vision of the late Kouoh. As the first African woman appointed to curate the central exhibition, she sought to connect the global through the “spirit and sacredness” of marginalised places and people. (Something unwittingly echoed in the protests.) Artists have interpreted the theme, ‘In Minor Keys’, through earth, ceramics, textiles and ancestral memory. This is felt deeply in the Arsenale and Giardini, from Moroccan artist Amina Saoudi



Aït Khay’s beautiful tapestries that refer to her Amazigh heritage and the landscapes of Morocco and Tunisia, to Maria Magdalena Campos-Pons’ *Anatomy of the Magnolia Tree for Koyo Kouoh and Toni Morrison* (2026). The Cuban artist’s work is the centrepiece at the Giardini, and features eight panels honouring American novelist Morrison and Kouoh, two titans of Black female intellectualism, surrounded by resin and glass sculptures of the magnolia, the iconic flower of the American South.

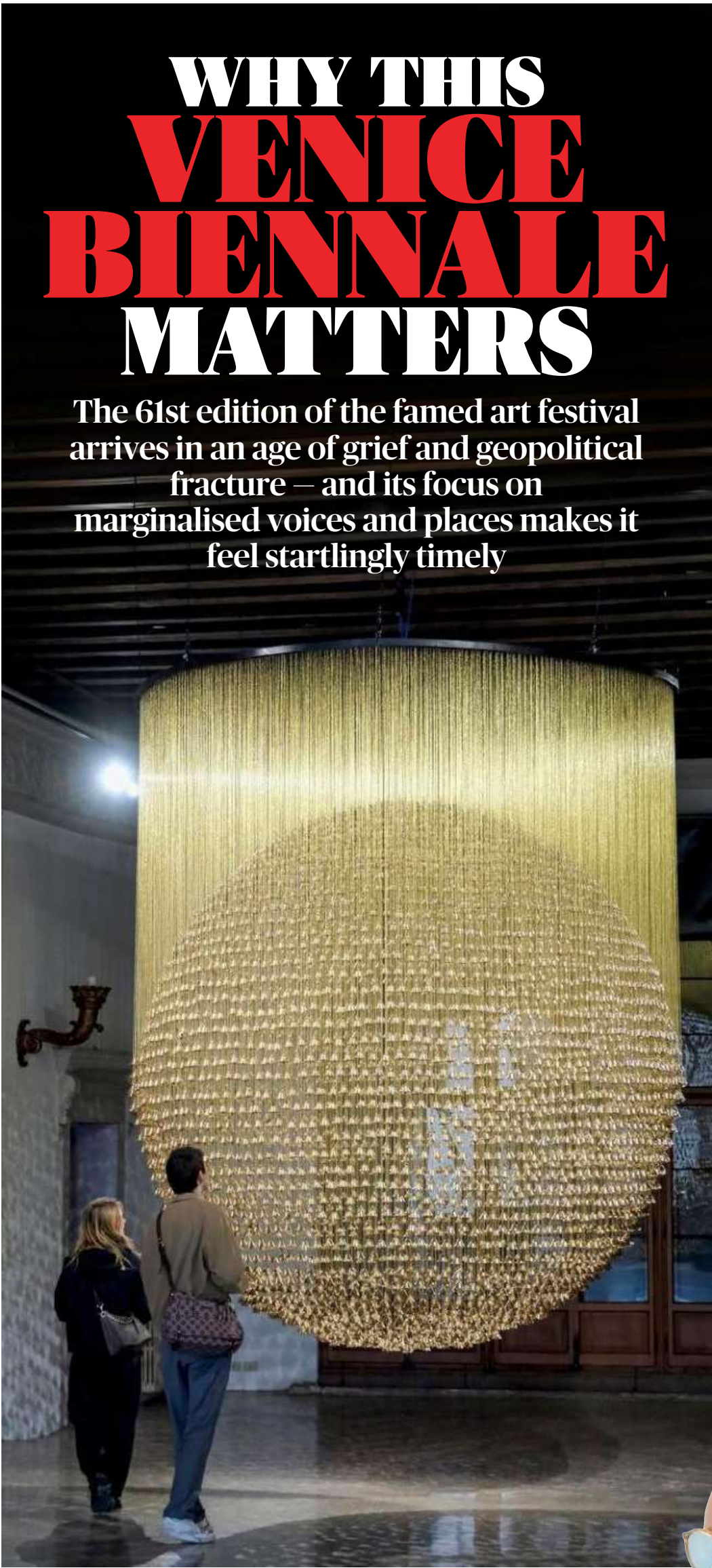
Masterclass in the tangible

This edition is strikingly tactile. Favourites among visitors include the intricate beadwork paintings by American artist Big Chief Demond Melancon, depicting the Black Masking culture of New Orleans – elaborate feathered and beaded works that are an expression of community resilience – and the ethereal blue-and-white *ikat* panels by Himali Singh Soin and David Soin Tappeser. The duo’s sonic-textile installation, presented by RMZ Foundation, draws on the geological connections between the Indian subcontinent and the polar regions, and invites visitors to ask what lies beneath the dominant frequencies of our time. Sound is translated into a handwoven cotton-and-ahimsa silk textile by a master artisan, Gajam Govardhan.

Meanwhile, the Moroccan Pavilion’s hand-spun, naturally dyed tapestries provide a masterclass in architectural textile. They allow you to revel in the narrow strips of woven, knotted and stitched artworks that hold stories through patterns and memories of home.

The weird and unexpected

The Biennale is always a study in sensory extremes. For some, the highlight is the whimsical, participatory nature of the Japan Pavilion, where visitors are invited to carry around baby dolls as part of the interactive installation *Grass Babies, Moon Babies*. It was



born out of the nurturing-rearing experience of queer artist Ei ArakawaNash, who became a parent of twins in 2024.

Others endure the notorious two-hour queue for the Austria Pavilion to witness the provocative spectacle of naked women on jet skis or submerged in a water tank (where urine from the toilet, passed through several filtration systems, top up the water level). Blending dance, theatre and performance, artist Florentina Holzinger uses her long-standing research into water – as both subject and symbol – in *Seaworld Venice* as a point of departure for an exploration of the human body in a radically changing landscape, in which nature and technology collide.

For those seeking a more profound immersion, the Polish

Pavilion reaches new heights. Inside, two giant screens – one angled precariously from the ceiling – tower over the space. Visitors are invited to lie upon a central stone slab, looking upward as performers (hearing and deaf) dressed in crimson communicate through a haunting, rhythmic blend of song and sign language. *Liquid Tongues* is a compelling experience, a moment of forced stillness in a city of constant motion.

A homecoming for India

Of particular significance this year is the India Pavilion, which is back after a seven-year hiatus. Supported by the Ministry of Culture – in partnership with the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre and Serendipity Arts – the exhibition, titled

Geographies of Distance: Remembering Home, is curated by Paris-based Amin Jaffer. Located at the meandering end of the Arsenale, the pavilion functions as a sensory threshold. Entering through heavy black curtains into a space of deliberate low lighting, the darkness slows the eye, forcing an immediate confrontation with material, scale and and pattern of shadows.

At its heart stands Asim Waqif’s colossal bamboo installation. Rising towards the rafters with overwhelming force, it echoes the ubiquitous scaffolding of Indian urban landscapes. It is a work that invites touch and sound; visitors drum against the stalks, breathing in the earthy fragrance of the wood. “I love the sound of the bamboo,” echoes among my artist friends. It feels both monumental and vulnerable, though the visible plastic ties

occasionally break the spell of its organic aesthetic.

To the right, Sumakshi Singh’s ‘ghostly’ thread-work installations offer a more spectral memory. She has created a *trompe l’oeil* replica of her ancestral home, capturing everything from decorative flourishes to the minutiae of hinges and bolts. “The fragile architecture of the work inhabits a tension between shelter and exposure, presence and disappearance,” says Singh, noting that the pavilion allowed her to finally realise her work at a truly monumental scale. “It becomes a meditation on what persists within us, even as the outer world dissolves.” It is a profound experience to walk through her thread-drawn doorways, navigating the interplay of shadow and memory.

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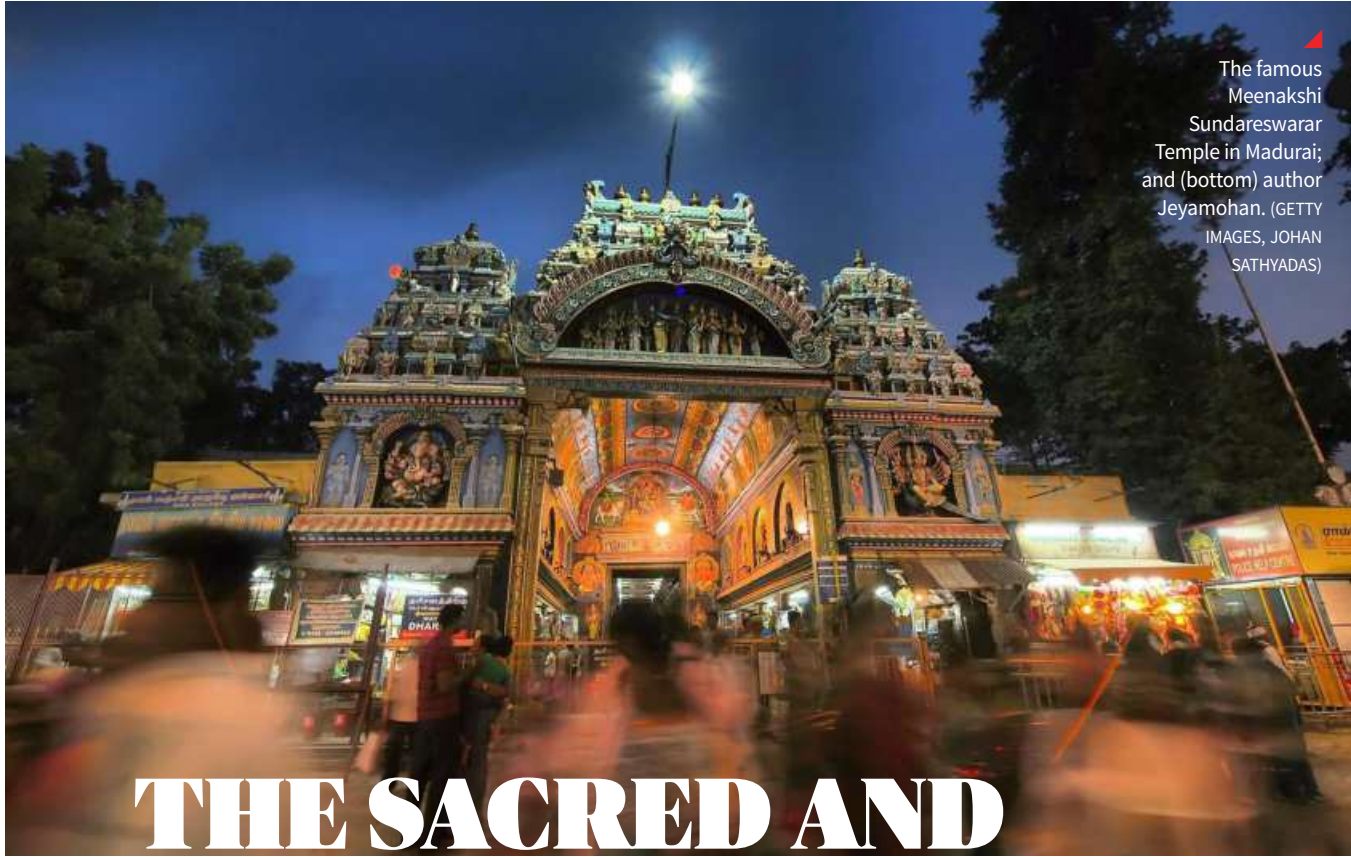


Politicisation of the city

Venice is one of the longest running and most prestigious art biennales in the world. With a 129-year history, it runs for close to 200 days, has over 100 countries participating, and the last edition saw 700,000 tickets sold during its seven-month run. This year, the 61st Venice Biennale (May 9-November 22) opened under an atmosphere of grief and geopolitical tension. In the preview week, the torrential rain and thunderstorms seemed an appropriate accompaniment to the protests over the participation of Russia and Israel, culminating in the unprecedented resignation of the Biennale’s entire prize jury just days before the opening. Over 80 artists withdrew from the awards as an act of solidarity, and 25 pavilions, including France, Belgium, Britain and Italy, closed for a day. As Shwetal Patel, the writer and researcher who heads international programmes at the Kochi-Muziris Biennale, points out, “Artists and audiences alike are demanding greater justice especially at international events such as these.”



(Clockwise from above) *Grass Babies, Moon Babies* at the Japan Pavilion; Ashfika Rahman’s installation at the Ukraine Pavilion; Maria Campos-Pons’ *Anatomy of the Magnolia Tree for Koyo Kouoh and Toni Morrison*; Ranjani Shettar’s artwork at the India Pavilion; and protests in Venice. (GETTY IMAGES)



The famous Meenakshi Sundareswarar Temple in Madurai; and (bottom) author Jeyamohan. (GETTY IMAGES, JOHAN SATHYADAS)

THE SACRED AND THE SINISTER

Two recent translations of Tamil author Jeyamohan’s works straddle completely different worlds – devotion and faith, crime and the human psyche

Akila Kannadasan
akila.k@thehindu.co.in

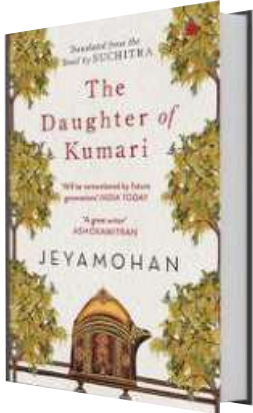
There is a moment when we finish a novel; when we read its very last word, close it, and stare at nothing in particular, thinking about it. Jeyamohan’s *The Daughter of Kumari* had me visualising a little girl – a little ‘imp’ as he puts it – playing in the dusty streets of Madurai, her long, fish-like eyes sparkling, planning her next mischief. This translation of *Kumarithurai*, simply put, is the story of the grandest wedding of all time, one in which nothing can go wrong. Almost.

Jeyamohan visualises the grand farewell that Meenakshi, the goddess-queen of Madurai, is given when she goes back home after spending 59 years in exile in Venad, near Kumari. What will happen if one day, a kingdom’s daughter, its guardian deity, is asked to be sent back to where she came from?

In the 14th century, when Madurai is invaded by Allauddin Khilji’s troops, the idol of goddess Meenakshi is secretly sent away to the kingdom of Venad for safety. Decades later, she is asked to be returned.

A devoted portrait
Jeyamohan tells the story through the first-person narrative of Thenkulum Kattalaikkaran Veeramarthandan Udayan Chempakaraman, the chief administrator to the king of Venad. It opens with Chempakaraman riding on horseback bearing important news for his Maharaja.

He tells the king: “Sir, we will receive news to return *ammai* Meenakshi.” News that a Nayaka king wants to rebuild Madurai and reinstate its ruling goddess is not exactly bad news, but a bit ‘unwelcome’. The king of Venad agrees to return her, for it is the right thing to do. He will see her off as he would his daughter, giving her away in marriage to the handsome



The Daughter of Kumari
Jeyamohan, trs Suchitra Juggernaut
₹499

Lord Sundaresan, who will arrive from Madurai, seeking her hand.

Jeyamohan goes on to describe the scale of the celestial wedding that unfolds in Venad. Preparations give the organisers sleepless nights – from ensuring all the rituals are carried out to the T, curating the bride’s elaborate trousseau, organising feasts fit for thousands of people, erecting hundreds of *pandals* for the festivities, to building new roads for people to reach the venue from near and far and digging ponds for visitors to bathe – there is much to do in very little time.

Tensions run high. But deep down, readers know that all will end well in a work that Jeyamohan describes in his foreword as one of ‘*mangalam*’, meaning auspiciousness.

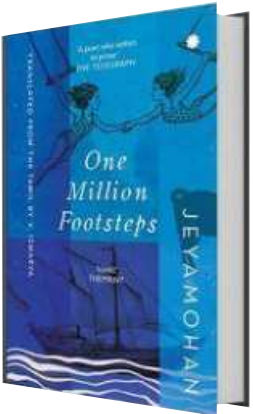
He goes to great lengths to detail not just the wedding arrangements, but the mindset of the people involved: the king, the father of the goddess-bride who cries inconsolably at the prospect of his daughter leaving his home; the chief administrator, the organiser of the mammoth event, who breaks down upon seeing the *thaali* around Meenakshi’s neck when she is wedded to Sundaresan... Suchitra’s translation flows as smooth as a river, and she manages to render the novel’s many ritualistic descriptions without them appearing tedious.

On the killer’s trail

If *The Daughter of Kumari* is steeped in auspiciousness and collective devotion, *One Million Footsteps* turns its gaze toward the darker recesses of human nature, trading temple corridors and wedding feasts for smoky bars and the troubled minds of criminals.

One Million Footsteps is a collection of detective stories featuring the bad-mouthing, whisky-guzzling genius of an ex-police officer, Ousepachan. This translation of *Pathu Latsham Kaaladigal* is more about the people who commit the crime – Jeyamohan dwells on the workings of their mind, digging deep into their thoughts, morals, and views of the world around them.

Years of studying gun-wielding smugglers, murderers, petty thieves, and law-breakers from the unlikely of places has left



One Million Footsteps
Jeyamohan, trs V. Iswarya Juggernaut
₹499

Ousepachan with an uncanny understanding of human nature, not to mention a remarkable ability to solve a crime, even if that means relentlessly pursuing a lead to the end of the world. Each of the five stories here unfolds as friendly banter amidst Ousepachan and his gang of friends – Kumaran Master, Sreedharan Nair, and the narrator, a

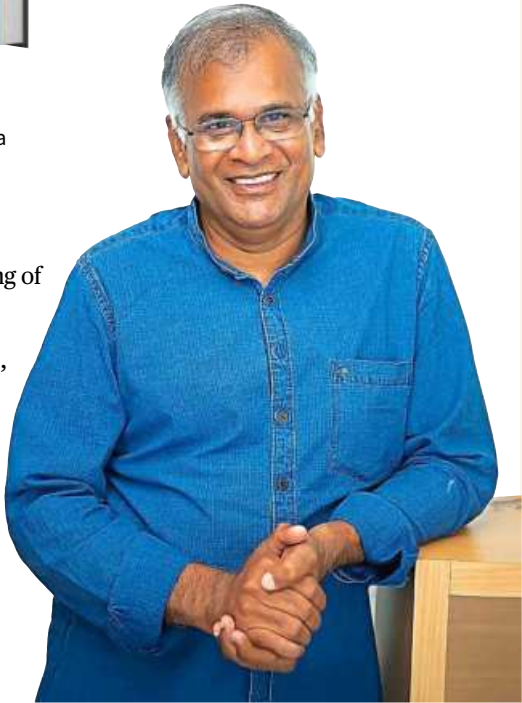
half-Malayali, half-Tamil writer.

Their meetings happen in places whose names themselves paint a picture in our minds – Muscat Hotel in Thiruvananthapuram; Aswathy Club in Kumarakom, an inn in Muzhappilangad. In between his many drinks and belching and mocking his friends, Ousepachan narrates chilling stories about the crimes he solved in his illustrious career.

These are not any crime stories – Ousepachan or Jeyamohan, rather, doesn’t go straight to the matter. He sets the tone with a rich tapestry: of Kerala’s history or life in a circus for artistes from Thalassery, for instance, before taking us into the core of the crime committed – what pushes people to cross the line, changing their lives forever.

There is a mass-murder story with a *yakshi*, another featuring Ousepachan’s *guru* Afonso Rosario, a handsome, actor Sarath Babu-lookalike who was called ‘Sherlock’. Even as the ex-police officer takes many refills and meanders on and off, we hang on to his every word, much like his friends. He takes us into a 200-year-old house made of jackfruit wood that holds a sinister secret, into the smuggling cartels of the west coast, to the banks of the Netravati River in Mangaluru where a murder unfolds one rainy night in a farmhouse within an eight-acre coconut grove...

V. Iswarya’s translation keeps up with the pace of the narration that leaves us on the edge of our seats, even as we marvel at Ousepachan’s cool-headed ingenuity.



IN CONVERSATION

A cinematic take

Translator Ross Benjamin on working with German author Daniel Kehlmann for the International Booker-shortlisted novel, *The Director*

Saurabh Sharma

Previously nominated for the International Booker Prize in 2020 for his translation of *Tyll* by German writer Daniel Kehlmann, Ross Benjamin returns to this year’s shortlist with Kehlmann’s *The Director* (published by riverrun). The novel fictionalises the life of G.W. Pabst, the pioneering German filmmaker who not only broke new ground in the art of film editing but also discovered actors Greta Garbo and Louise Brooks.

Under the Third Reich, Pabst compromised his art in order to survive and make films for the Nazi establishment. While Kehlmann’s German prose captures Pabst’s life frame by frame on the page, Benjamin renders it in English with equal cinematic force. In this conversation, he discusses the novel’s recurring themes and reflects on the pleasures of translating Kehlmann’s work. Edited excerpts:

Question: What drew you to translating Daniel Kehlmann’s novel?

Answer: The book appeared in German before the 2024 presidential election in the U.S. The kinds of cultural dynamics that now make its parallels with American life so striking were already present, but they had not yet taken on the same force for me while I was translating it. That changed by the time I finished.

What drew me in from the start was also Kehlmann’s humour, wit, and intelligence and his extraordinary feel for history in all its specificity. One of his gifts is making the past seem uncannily immediate. At the time, though, I still had enough distance from the material to register those qualities primarily as artistic ones. Later, that distance collapsed. The novel’s echoes in Trump’s America became harder to miss, especially in the spectacle of cultural figures behaving as though they lacked freedoms they, in fact, still possessed, whereas in Pabst’s world, things had already grown much darker by the time he began accommodating himself to the regime.

Q: How did you transpose the ‘shots’, as Kehlmann reflects on writing this book, from German to English?

A: As a translator, I was very aware of the novel’s cinematic techniques. Readers might notice scenes that seem to unfold as if through a moving camera, or that evoke the atmosphere of early German cinema. In one chapter especially, Pabst experiences his own life as if he were editing it while living through it. Given his importance as a filmmaker and innovator of editing technique, that conceit was central to the story. So, part of the task was to preserve



German filmmaker G.W. Pabst, on whose life *The Director* is based; and (left) the book’s translator Ross Benjamin. (GETTY IMAGES)

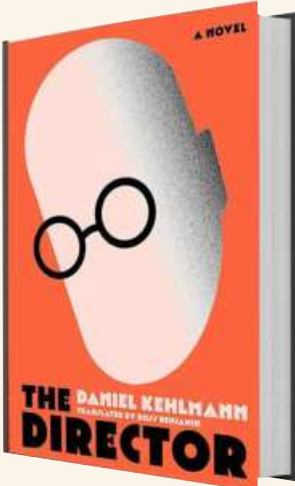


those elements in English: the pacing, cuts, perspectival shifts, the play of intimacy and dissociation. Translation does sometimes make me think of film adaptation. The analogy holds only to a point, but both require you to remake something formally.

Q: In both *Tyll* and *The Director*, the titular characters’ myths introduce us to them. What are your views on this technique?

A: I hadn’t actually noticed that parallel. But yes, in both novels, Kehlmann initially presents the central figure through other people’s accounts and impressions. It’s certainly effective. I can’t say how deliberate it was on his part, since I wasn’t conscious of it myself until now. It may sound odd, but a translator is sometimes more explicitly aware of what an author is doing than the author is. The author may arrive there by intuition, whereas the translator has to ask, sentence by sentence, what kind of effect is being created and how. In any case, it’s an old and powerful narrative device. Plenty of stories begin by surrounding a figure with hearsay, legend, or reported experience before bringing that person onstage. It may be as old as storytelling itself.

Q: Pabst’s difficulty with the English language materialises differently, and is often



tragicomic. Say, using ‘floor’ to mean ‘tier’.

A: Those are exactly the places where the challenge and pleasure of translation lie. If ‘Brot’ is just ‘bread’, there’s next to nothing the translator has to do. But when a novel is staging linguistic awkwardness, misunderstanding or comedy, you can’t just proceed word by word. The ‘second floor’ for ‘second tier’ moment had to be reinvented, because Kehlmann is misusing a different expression in German to achieve the same effect. There are several scenes like that in the book, where Germans are portrayed as speaking English and the humour depends on the friction between the two languages. That’s when fidelity becomes most interesting, when it might mean doing something quite new in English to recreate as precisely and compellingly as possible what the original is doing.

The interviewer is a Delhi-based queer writer and culture critic.

BROWSER

The School-Gate Kidnapping

Kiran Manral
Rupa
₹395
Combining elements of female-detective mystery, celebrity scandal and social satire, the author crafts a story about obsession, ambition and gloriously stubborn determination. Mumbai-based Manral is also a co-host of the podcast *Not Your Aunty*.



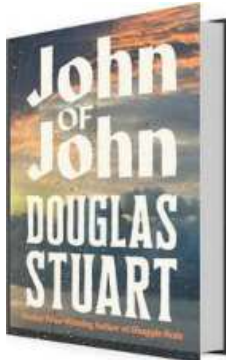
The Midnight Train

Matt Haig
Penguin
₹799
This spiritual companion to the 2020 bestseller *The Midnight Library* is a “time-travelling love story”. The cover design, depicting two lovers framed in adjacent windows, was chosen through a fan vote on social media, with readers also contributing creative input, the author shared on Instagram.



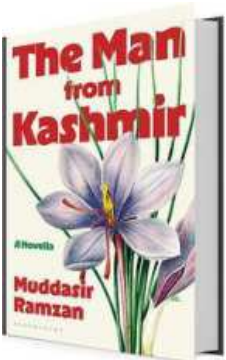
John of John

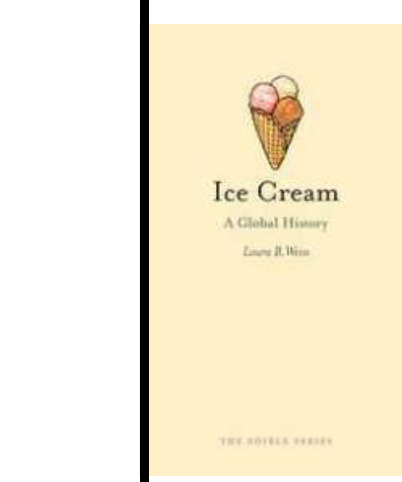
Douglas Stuart
Picador
₹899
The Booker Prize-winning author’s latest novel explores a gay father and son’s struggle to preserve familial bonds within a deeply conservative Scottish community. Stuart wrote his award-winning debut book *Shuggie Bain* over a decade, while juggling his job as a successful fashion designer.



The Man from Kashmir

Muddasir Ramzan
Bloomsbury
₹499
The author and academic whose interest areas include the contemporary realities of Muslims and post-9/11 literature, explores the fractured reality of life in the Valley in this debut work. Folk tales, political realities and dystopia add layers to this novella set in a fictional Kashmiri town.





Pranavi Sharma

One spring morning in Delhi, Isha Desai, a 24-year-old student, picks up a copy of Ali M. Ansari’s *Iran: A Very Short Introduction* just before stepping out of a bookshop. Asked what piqued her interest in the book, she says, “I have always been interested in world history, but my hectic routine doesn’t allow me the time for 1,000-page volumes. So, I have recently started looking for slimmer books.”

Concise non-fiction books of 100 to 300 pages are hardly new to Indian publishing. Still, the arrival of three dedicated series in recent times prompts a question: why now? Is this simply a trend, or a sign of broader changes in the publishing landscape?

Aleph Book Company’s ‘Essential India Editions’ series, launched in 2025, consists of tightly argued books on national themes, designed for quick reading. Its publications include Shashi Tharoor’s *Our Living Constitution*, Valmiki Thapar’s *The Mysterious World of Tigers*, and Amitava Kumar’s *The Social Life of Indian Trains*.

Pan Macmillan India continues to publish ‘The Shortest History’ series, which it started in 2022. Titles include Ross King’s *The Shortest History of Ancient Rome*, David Baker’s *The Shortest History of Sex*, and Michael Scott-Baumann’s *The Shortest History of Israel and Palestine*. In January this year, the publishing house also introduced the ‘Edible Series’, with condensed histories of civilisations and food. This includes Laura B. Weiss’s work on ice cream, Jonathan Morris’s on coffee, Joseph M. Carlin’s on cocktails, and Ramin Ganeshram’s on saffron.

This shift reflects changing patterns in how knowledge circulates, how time is valued, and



WHY INDIA IS TURNING TO SLIM NON-FICTION BOOKS

Whether bought on impulse, to meet yearly reading goals, or read as introductions to complex ideas, compact books are carving out a larger place in Indian publishing

who reads. India is increasingly driving global non-fiction growth. Between January and August 2025, 11 of the 19 markets tracked by NielsenIQ BookData saw revenue rise over the previous year. India led with 28.6 percent growth. Non-fiction revenue rose across eight countries, with bestselling titles including *Atomic Habits* by James Clear and *The Let Them Theory* by Mel Robbins. The popularity of these

books suggests a growing appetite for practical, actionable non-fiction, and also points to how shrinking attention spans, rising book prices, and reduced leisure time could be shaping reading habits.

Filling the gap
When Sayantan Bishnu from West Bengal was studying literature a few years ago, he also had to engage with philosophy. “But I couldn’t dive

straight into the thicker editions of Gilles Deleuze or Friedrich Nietzsche,” he says. Slim books, Bishnu explains, condense ideas that might otherwise be scattered across “15 or 16 books” into a single, approachable text that is not daunting. “Without such an introduction, most readers would not even know where to start with these subjects,” he says.

Constance L. Kirker, who co-authored *Mango: A Global History* with Mary Newman taught for several semesters at the ‘Semester at Sea’ programme at the University of Virginia in the U.S. It takes roughly 600 students to more than 10 countries over the course of a single term. Before arriving at each place, the entire student body would attend a joint lecture that would introduce them to the next destination.

“Imagine being allotted just 15-20 minutes in a team presentation to explain what students should know about Indian art before the ship

arrived in Chennai,” says Kirker. “The process really focuses the mind.” Years of working within such constraints – condensing complexity without distorting it – help explain why slim, cogently argued books have become a practical response to the way people seek knowledge today, she adds.

Kirker and Newman say that the cultural change is obvious everywhere. Kirker says, “We don’t think there is any doubt that attention spans are shorter. We all want answers instantly. The Internet and AI have created expectations of instant gratification.”

Readers also say what they enjoy most is finishing a book, sometimes just to stay on track with yearly reading goals. Aligarh-based book blogger Mir Khubaib Ali says he often turns to Penguin’s Little Black Classics to keep pace with his targets.

Impulse buys
Slim non-fiction books also sell because of the way they are positioned at bookstores. Much like candy, they are often tactfully placed near cash registers and are picked up without much planning. Ajay Jain, founder of Kunzum bookstore in New Delhi, says, “Most of them are impulse buys.” Interestingly, when kept near a cash

India is increasingly driving global non-fiction growth. Between January and August 2025, 11 of the 19 markets tracked by NielsenIQ BookData saw revenue rise over the previous year. India led with 28.6% growth.

register, “their sales go up,” but once they are moved to regular shelves, they “tend to get lost among bigger titles,” he explains. Price, too, plays a role in sales. As Jain says, “Most of these books are relatively affordable, [priced ₹150-₹599, with many being on the lower end of the scale] so customers think: “That’s not expensive, and it seems like an easy read. Let’s add it to the bill too.” Jain also draws attention to how visibility shapes demand. He notes that these books also sell partly because they are actively pushed through social media.

Loss of nuance?
Some may argue that dense ideas cannot be condensed without some loss of argument or nuance. The linguist and literary critic, G.N. Devy, responds, “Slim books need to be presented in a compressed but not curtailed manner.” Their main limitation, he says, is that they cannot satisfy the author’s desire to display everything they know. Yet this constraint can also be a strength: the format forces careful selection and quickly reveals weak arguments. Devy says they make it easier for people to join public discussions about the nation, the Constitution, language, or culture. When asked if seriousness is measured by the number of pages, writer and dancer Leela Samson, whose *Dance of Freedom: A Short History of Bharata Natyam* was published in 2025 by Aleph Book Company, responds, “Are big ideas only explained in large books? How does a mother explain to a child what death is when it happens in a small house?”

Pujitha Krishnan, editorial director at Pan Macmillan India, says we live at a time when history is being contested and subverted. “There is an urgent need for accessible and meticulously researched books that serve to rectify misinformation, inaccuracies, and half-truths,” she says. But this, according to publishers, doesn’t necessarily mean an intellectual decline or a dumbing down of information. As Aienla Ozukum, publisher at Aleph Book Company, says, “Serious readers will still read important, large books.” But slim books have always had a place in the ecosystem. She says. Her aim is to provoke deeper reflection among “intelligent lay readers” – those who assume they already understand the Constitution or the national flag – by encouraging a closer read of these subjects. Devy sums up the trend best; as he says, “A ghazal is as much music as a *raagdari* rendition.”

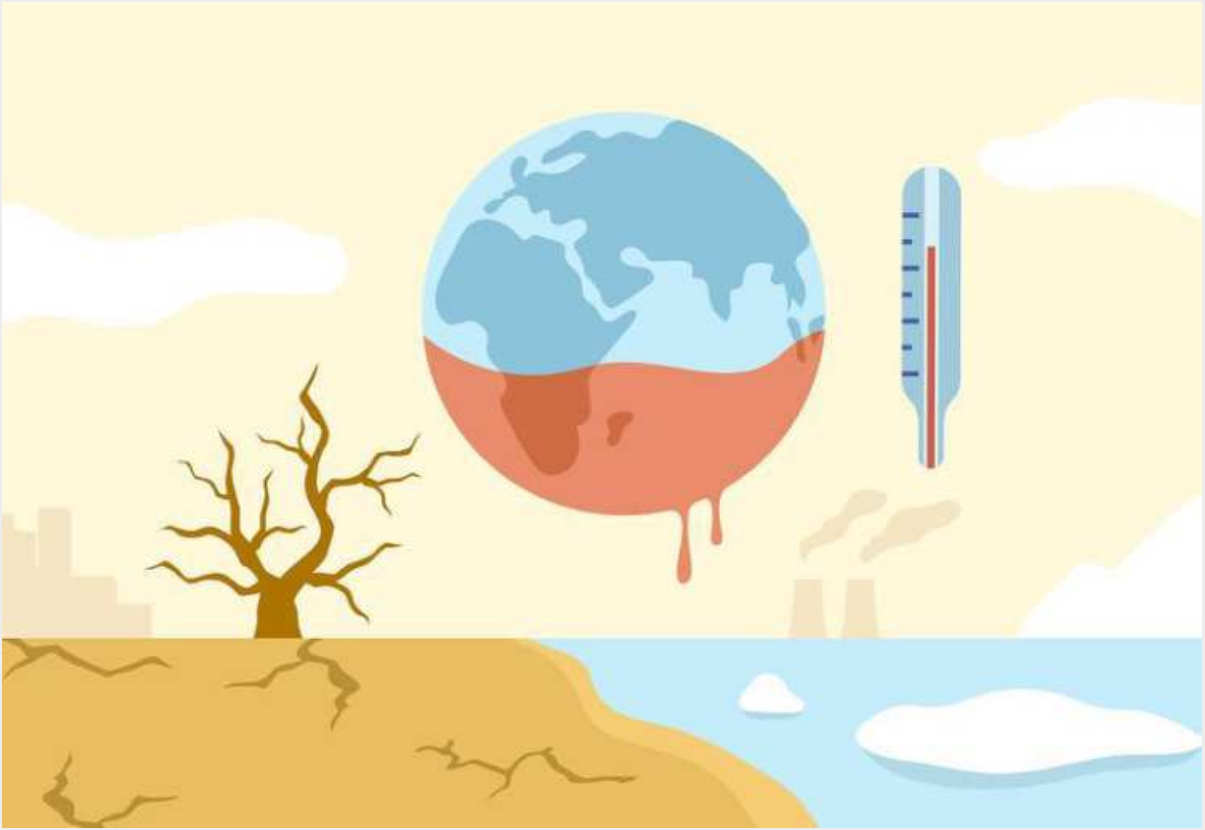
The writer is an independent journalist based in Delhi.

Against the velocity of modern life

Vandana Shiva and Shreya Jani’s book encourages us to slow down in a world addicted to speed and excess

Ameer Shahul

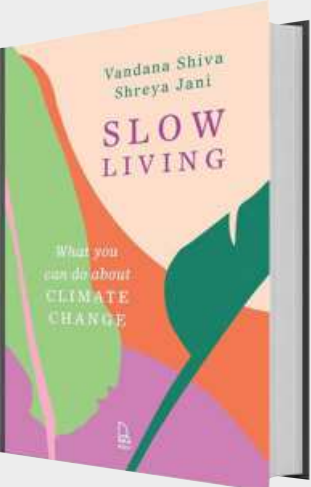
There is something quietly subversive about *Slow Living: What You Can Do About Climate Change* by Vandana Shiva and Shreya Jani. It does not shout, alarm, or overwhelm with graphs or apocalyptic urgency. Instead, it asks an uncomfortable question: what if the climate crisis is not just out there in melting glaciers and rising seas, but embedded in the rhythm of your own life? At first glance, the premise feels deceptively simple. But as you move through the pages, the book encourages you to slow down in a world addicted to speed and excess. Beneath this simplicity lies a deeper provocation: the authors are not merely advocating lifestyle changes, but challenging the very architecture of modern living. The strength of the book lies in how it reframes climate action. In an era dominated by policy frameworks, carbon accounting, and technological optimism, *Slow Living* shifts the locus of change to the everyday. It positions food, clothing, work, health, and relationships not just as personal choices, but as ecological acts. Beyond this, it extends the idea of slowness to knowledge, the economy, democracy, and culture.



The argument that climate change persists not only because of industrial systems, but because those systems are dynamically reproduced through our habits is subtle and powerful. The modern economy is presented as fundamentally misaligned with the

original rhythms of nature. The book, in essence, is a manifesto for a new way of living through a call for individual transformation in a changing world. It weaves in insights from saints and philosophers. From assertions such as “we forget that we are

members of an Earth Family, and the real economy is an economy of care – care for the planet and for one another,” to observations such as “the concentration of wealth accumulated through violence and wars was mystified into capital,” the book is rich with ideas.



Slow Living: What You Can Do About Climate Change
Vandana Shiva and Shreya Jani
Roli Books
₹895

Shiva and Jani’s writing carries a certain stillness. It is almost meditative and often reads like a conversation. Drawing from Shiva’s long-standing engagement with ecological movements, the book distills these ideas into a more accessible, lived philosophy. The tone avoids confrontation, yet the critique is unmistakable. One of the most compelling aspects of the book is its insistence that “slowness” is resistance. In a world where efficiency is celebrated and time is commodified, choosing

to slow down is an act of defiance. As modern lifestyles make ordering food more common than cooking, replacing more convenient than repairing, and buying easier than growing, *Slow Living* calls for a conscious reversal of this destructive trajectory. But for all its clarity, the book sometimes underestimates the structural constraints within which individuals operate. It forgets the fact that slowness is not equally accessible to everyone. For a daily-wage worker, a gig economy employee, or even an urban professional caught in cycles of economic pressure, slowing down is often a privilege rather than a choice. While the book acknowledges systemic issues, its solutions remain largely anchored in individual transformation. This tension between systemic critique and individual action is not fully resolved in the pages. Shiva and Jani gesture towards broader change but stop short of deeply engaging with the political and economic machinery that accelerates speed and consumption. As a result, the book occasionally risks coming across more as moral persuasion and less as structural analysis. However, to judge it solely on these grounds would be to miss its intention. *Slow Living* is neither an academic treatise nor a policy document. Its purpose is not to provide exhaustive solutions, but to shift perception. And in that, it succeeds remarkably well.

The reviewer is a climate change and healthcare activist and author of Heavy Metal and Vaccine Nation.

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Though the work is fragile (I fear there will be too many hands poking through it), visitors are guided by invigilators to move carefully through the structures and to not touch the artwork – a challenge given how tactile it is and how interactive the bamboo artwork is.

On the opposite flank, Ranjani Shettar's resin-coated flowers and seed pods hang in a state of suspended animation, hovering between growth and collapse. These contrast with Alwan Balasubramaniam's cracked earthworks, which, framed upon the walls, elevate the very ground we walk upon into high art. While the Skarma Sonam Tashi on the upper level felt somewhat disconnected from the main floor's dialogue, the viewing platform allowed for a panoramic scan of a pavilion that felt, for the most part, like a cohesive, breathing entity.

Others to check out If the India Pavilion is a glorious spectacle, by contrast, on the other side of the island, artist Nalini Malani's large-scale work of 67 animations (made from 30,000 iPad drawings) across nine projections, is dark and deliberately disturbing. Set inside a cavernous, brick-walled salt warehouse, *Of Women Born*, presented by KNMA and curated by Robinia Karode, is an undeniable statement about the position



WHY THIS VENICE BIENNALE MATTERS



Navigating the Floating City

If you are staying along the Grand Canal, be prepared for tourists making their way to St. Mark's Square and the Rialto Bridge. If you want to avoid water taxis, stay within walking distance of the Castello district because that is where the main areas of the exhibition are. My top tip: if you are heading out during peak hours, try to seek entry via the rear – you will avoid lengthy queues.

While you never know what to expect, see or experience at the Venice Biennale, with over 100 artists in group exhibitions alone (which you can see at the Giardini and Arsenale), and thousands more spread across the city in collaterals, there really is a sense of true discovery when you come here.

Also, once you come out of the Biennale, wandering around the city is like being in a maze. But no matter where you end up, you will always be guaranteed homemade pasta, freshly ground coffee and artisanal ice cream.

South Asian presence

British sculptor Anish Kapoor's exhibition at Palazzo Manfrin brings together around 100 architectural models of projects. Bangladeshi visual artist Ashfika Rahman's installation *Than Para – No Land Without Us* is not to be missed. Composed of nearly 5,000 temple bells, each one bears collected thumb prints of displaced people from the Chittagong Hill Tract regions – transforming individual traces into a moving testament of presence, memory, belonging, and the enduring claim to land and identity. There's also London-based artist Faiza Butt who is channelling Punjab's textile and craft traditions into bold forms at the Pakistan Pavilion.

Asim Waqif's colossal bamboo installation at the India Pavilion; and (below) *The Mona Lisa is Drowning*, a work by street artist TVBoy. (GETTY IMAGES)

of women in the midst of wars and violence. Sohrab Hura's *Timelines*, part of the main exhibition in the Giardini, is a sprawling series of candid snapshots of ordinary lives, unfolding across a series of cardboard boxes.

Elsewhere, at the historic Marinaressa Gardens, artist Pareeh Maity's abstract cuboid sculpture, *Equilibrium*, envisions the universe as a carefully balanced system, drawing upon the four cardinal directions and the four

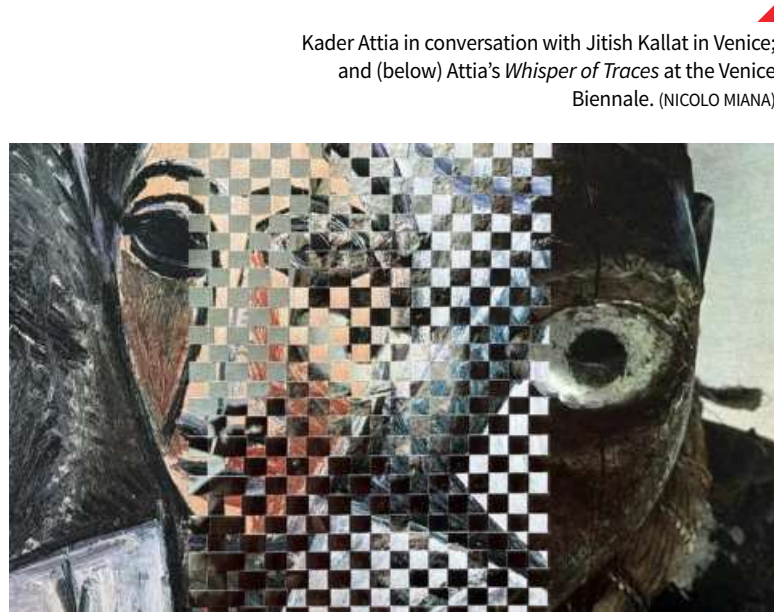
cosmic corners of traditional Indian spatial philosophy. There's also photographer Dayanita Singh's tribute to the Italian archives she has photographed over the past decade and her own evolving archive of images made in Italy over the last 25 years, presented at Archivio di Stato.

Make the pilgrimage The Venice Biennale remains an unparalleled intensity. It is the only place where the global zeitgeist is distilled into a few square miles of lagoon-soaked land. Through the vision of Kuouh and the evocative return of pavilions such as India's, the 61st edition reminds us that art's greatest power lies in its ability to bring us back to our own sense of being in the world.

The writer is an independent curator of textiles based in the U.K.



Scan the QR code to see art and conversations from Venice, on magazine.thehindu.com



Uthra Raigopal

In Venice, a city built on the ebb and flow of maritime trade routes, migration and spectacle, the announcement of the seventh edition of the Kochi-Muziris Biennale (KMB) felt especially resonant.

In the frenzied choreography of the Venice Biennale preview week, Indian gallerists, curators and artists paused in the afternoon sunshine in the open courtyard at Ocean Space.

There couldn't have been a more fitting location. Here was a cultural arts venue set in the 16th-century Church of San Lorenzo, fabled as the final resting place of explorer Marco Polo. Suspended between history and the future, we took our seats.

KMB's co-founder Shwetal Patel's introduction – simultaneously live-streamed in Kochi – reminded us that the port city in Kerala was no longer a peripheral participant in the global art conversation, but a space actively reshaping it, with its last

edition attracting nearly 700,000 visitors. The tone was quietly celebratory with no hint of its recent troubles (such as the stepping down of Bose Krishnamachari as president of the Kochi Biennale Foundation).

There was a hushed silence. Then artist Jitish Kallat, the newly appointed president, made the announcement: Kader Attia will be KMB's next curator. There were cries of surprise, and a congratulatory round of applause, as the 55-year-old French-Algerian artist and academic walked up, dressed casually in a grey woollen beanie and jeans.

An outsider of non-Indian origin I caught up with Attia immediately after the announcement. We moved to a nearby wine bar and, as we chatted, I asked about his ideas of location and movement because, being a diasporic Indian living in the U.K., the scrutiny of representation and authenticity is always present. How was he, an outsider-of non-Indian origin, with no Indian language skills, going to curate what is now recognised as

one of the world's leading art biennales?

He was not remotely fazed by this. "For me, a curator is like a fold between worlds. Artists, communities, artworks, conversations – all of these are different spaces that must somehow connect," he said.

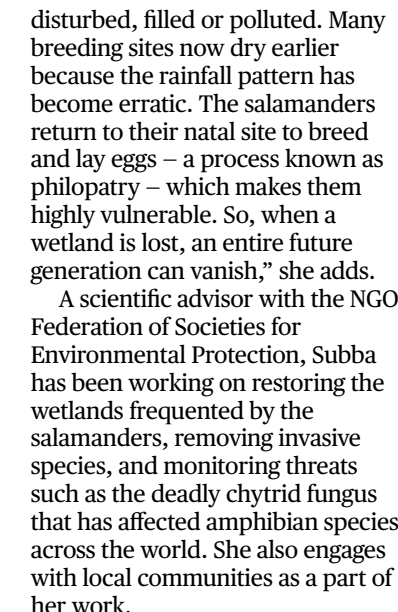
"During my experience running La Colonne in Paris [the now-closed art space and intellectual hub], I realised that when discussions become too theoretical or too ideological, people stop listening to each other. But when people bring an object, something

personal, suddenly connections emerge. That is very important for me in Kochi. The Biennale cannot represent only one generation, one aesthetic or one social position. It has to reflect the complexity of society itself. I'm very interested in creating projects where artists and local communities work together collectively."

It was clear that Attia had already started to think about how he would frame the 2027-28 edition, regarding Kochi as an interconnected space – not just through art, but through its streets and markets, where he has closely

observed movement and encounters, even how people negotiate the traffic on the roads. He isn't a stranger to Kochi. Besides visiting the last edition, Attia also participated in the 2014 edition of KMB. Soon, he will be relocating there with his family to embed himself more fully, and work with the art ecosystems of Kerala.

'Audiences tired of repetitive rhetoric' Rather than imagining the next Biennale solely as a constellation of exhibition venues, he described it



Where the Indian skimmer nests A similar initiative is helping the Indian skimmer along the Chambal river where it nests every year.

Shaikh, a scientist with the Bombay Natural History Society, has been working on conserving the bird species since 2016. She is the founder of the Guardians of the Skimmer initiative, which involves local communities in protecting and monitoring the nests of the bird. Numbering around 3,000 in India, the skimmer nests primarily along the banks of the Chambal (originating in Madhya Pradesh and flowing through Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh to join the Yamuna) from March to June, and is highly susceptible to attacks from feral animals, including dogs.

"The initiative not only provides

seasonal employment opportunities for local riverine communities, but also, as a consequence, leads to them taking an active interest in the protection of all native aquatic fauna," says Shaikh. As a result of these efforts over the last decade, the population of skimmers along the Chambal river has increased more than two-fold, from 400 individuals to over 1,000, while nest survival rates have also doubled in the same period.

Shaikh says that with the Whitley Award funding, the initiative can be expanded to Prayagraj in Uttar Pradesh, where the Ganga and Yamuna converge. "Prayagraj represents one of the most culturally and spiritually significant cities in India. Conservation efforts here must navigate pressures from pilgrimage-related disturbance, boat traffic, fishing and pollution," says a press release from the U.K. charity Whitley Fund for Nature, which gives out the Whitley Award. In addition to ₹50,000 (approx. ₹64.75 lakh) in project funding over one year, the awards provide exposure and training.

Both Shaikh and Subba acknowledge the role of local communities in protecting keystone species such as the skimmer and the salamander. "The river communities that work with us show that they are indeed a part of the solution in conservation practice. Conservation is equally about human communities as it is about wildlife," says Shaikh.

With two women winning the award, Shaikh hopes that others will be inspired to become scientists and conservationists. "The scenario is definitely changing, with more women becoming involved in conservation. But it is important that even more come forward to do so."

Neha Sinha, conservation biologist and author, says that the awards are an "important recognition" of lesser known species that are heavily dependent on conservation interventions in India. "Both species are nearly endemic to India yet do not have the popularity they should enjoy, in terms of policy or funding intervention," she says. "It is amazing not just that these talented women have been awarded, but also that their focus is on species which have largely been overlooked. Their work also draws attention to places outside protected areas, and the importance of hydrology for conservation and not just for human use."

A decade ago, I was trying to write about the then upcoming Bengal election. And I found inspiration in dog-eared comic books from my childhood.

The year is 2016 CE. Bharat is almost entirely occupied by the Lotus Party. Well, not entirely... One small corner of indomitable Bengalis still holds out against them... And life is not easy for the Delhi legionaries who garrison the fortified camps of Vidyasagar Setu toll plaza and Murshidabad toll plaza.

Five years later, it was still the same story: Mamata Banerjee as the Asterix of modern Indian politics starring in yet another edition of Didi and The Big Fight.

Mamata Banerjee, the hero of these adventures. A shrewd cunning little warrior; all perilous missions are immediately entrusted to her.

A fishy affair Each election, the cast of other characters kept changing around her. Obelix, Asterix's inseparable friend, always ready to drop everything and go off on a new adventure. Once it was her trusted lieutenant Mukul Roy, but then he started carrying menhirs for the BJP before returning to his village. At another time, it was Suvendu Adhikari, who not only switched camps but eventually led the charge that caused the sky to finally fall on Didi's head.

Getafix, the village druid, whose speciality is the potion which gives the drinker superhuman strength. In 2021, that seemed to be political strategist Prashant Kishor. This time around, the political consultancy IPAC took up the mantle.

But, like the Romans in the Asterix comics, I could never quite figure out what exactly was in the magic potion.

At one time, I thought, perhaps, Didi got her superhuman strength from *muri* (puffed rice). She was superwoman by being Everywoman. This year, PM Narendra Modi added his

magic *masala* to the *muri* by ordering *jhal muri* on the campaign trail, an image that went viral.

Then, Mamata Banerjee, once the Asterix of these adventures, suddenly finds herself playing a very different role at the traditional end-of-adventure village feast under the starry sky. In a plot twist, Asterix creators Goscinny and Uderzo could have never imagined she has become the bard Cacofonix, sidelined and speechless at the great *jhal muri* feast.

And all this poor Cacofonix can do now is mumble under her breath – *hamba hamba ramba ramba kamba kamba*. But for now, her state is singing a different tune.

Her artistic endeavours made her the butt of memes and reels. But she carried on unfazed, convinced culture would win her the big fight.

Talented or not, children in Bengal must always exhibit a "knack". I had a "knack" for painting and was shipped off to innumerable sit-and-draw competitions where I laboriously drew a Day at the Zoo for years. Children still sit staring at a piece of paper and crayons at these cut-throat



POP-A-RAZZI

Didi and the Romans

How Bengal's Asterix finally lost the big fight

cultural competitions while agitated mothers hiss instructions from across the fence. At the house across the street, half-a-dozen sisters practised their *sa re ga ma* scales every evening like clockwork. They sounded tuneless but they never gave up. And if all other knacks failed, the Bengali child was sent off to learn *abritti* (elocution) so he could impress the aunts with a dramatic rendition of a Tagore poem.

Culture was Didi's magic potion. But this time the magic potion finally ran out. By Tootatis, the wily modern-day Romans even came up with their own battle cry – Jai Shri Ram. And they cooked up their own magic potion. It had a bit of *jhal muri*, whole *rui* fish, central forces and SIR electoral roll revisions that struck crows off the list (a veritable Caesar's gift). They promised the electorate that with the fabled double-engine *sarkar* in Kolkata and Delhi, they would build the mansions of the gods in Bengal. In the end, while anti-incumbency had never been a problem in that comic-book corner of Gaul, it proved deadly in Ben-Gaul.

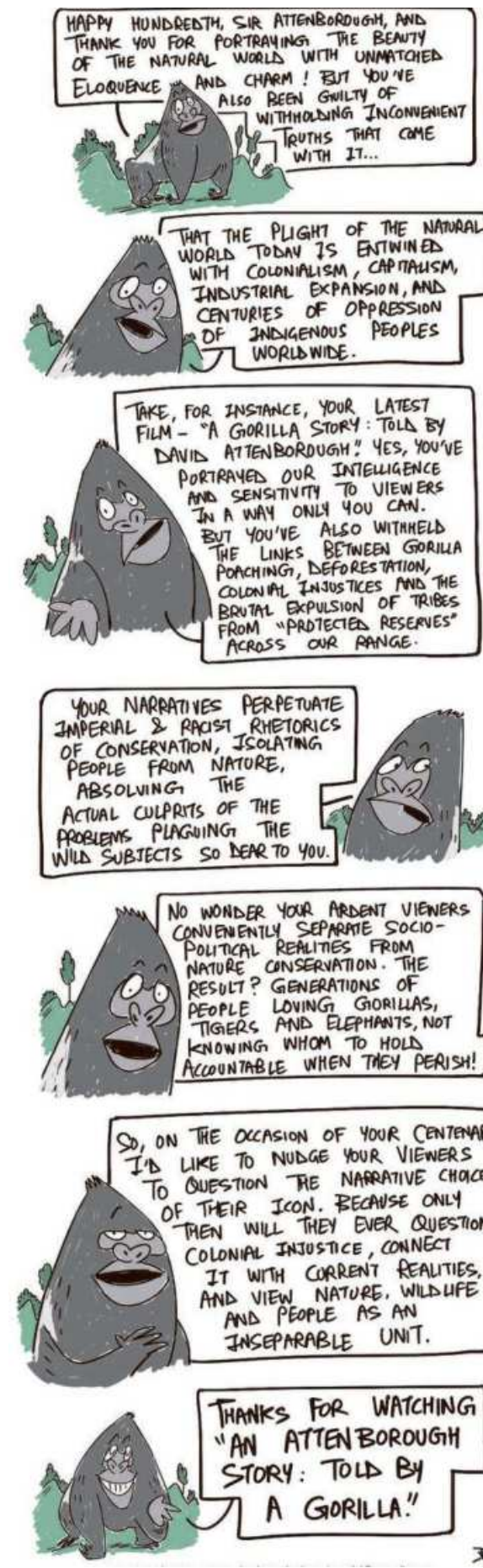
Thus, Mamata Banerjee, once the Asterix of these adventures, suddenly finds herself playing a very different role at the traditional end-of-adventure village feast under the starry sky. In a plot twist, Asterix creators Goscinny and Uderzo could have never imagined she has become the bard Cacofonix, sidelined and speechless at the great *jhal muri* feast.

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Sandip Roy is author of *Chapal Rani*, the Last Queen of Bengal.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Rohan Premkumar rohan.premkumar@thehindu.co.in

Growing up amid the lush forests and tea plantations of Darjeeling, conservation scientist Barkha Subba often spent hours wandering the woods around her home, "endlessly curious" about the creatures she encountered – birds, insects, frogs and snakes. Among them was one animal that especially captured her interest and later inspired her to become a conservation biologist fighting for its cause: the Himalayan salamander.

Subba is one of two Indian women this year to have won the prestigious Whitley Award, popularly known as the 'Green Oscars'. The award honours grassroots conservationists protecting landscapes and ecology in the Global South.

Parveen Shaikh, has been recognised for their work conserving two lesser-known species in India – the Himalayan salamander (*Tylosticta himalayensis*), a small "dragon-like" amphibian endemic to the hills of Darjeeling and Eastern Nepal; and the Indian skimmer (*Rynchops albicollis*), a white, black-capped bird with a bright orange bill. While the salamander is in serious decline due to habitat loss and listed as a 'vulnerable' species, the skimmer is endangered.

Both species remain little known outside conservation circles, despite serving as important indicators of the health of the ecosystems they inhabit. "They may not be charismatic or widely celebrated, but they are deeply important to the ecosystems they inhabit. When we protect an indicator species, we are also protecting forests, wetlands, streams, soil health, and entire ecological processes that countless other species – including people – depend on," says Subba.

Involving the local community The salamander was once widely distributed across Darjeeling, but is now restricted to less than 50 hectares of its former habitat. "What drew me to the Himalayan salamander was that it represented everything fragile and overlooked about our mountain ecosystems. Here was a species that had survived for millions of years, yet very few people even knew it existed," says Subba.

"Their home is disappearing. Wetlands are being drained,

FROM HIDDEN WILDS TO 'GREEN OSCARS'

Parveen Shaikh and Barkha Subba won the Whitley Award for their quiet fight to save a bird and an amphibian



Champions of ecology (Clockwise from above) Tea plantations of Darjeeling, where the Himalayan salamander (bottom right) is found; the Indian skimmer along the Chambal river in Central India; conservation scientists Parveen Shaikh and Barkha Subba. (COURTESY WHITLEY FUND FOR NATURE)

Bittu Sahgal

You either loved and admired the late Desmond Morris, or wrote him off as a maverick artist, writer and zoologist often accused of misogyny because of his views on evolution from the perspective of male sexual behaviour, which he treated no different from that of any other animal.

I disagree. In my book, he was a unique thinker who arrived at the same conclusion as Charles Darwin, a century apart. And spelled out the understanding of human evolutionary behaviour for millions between the pages of his celebrated (reviled by some) book, *The Naked Ape: A Zoologist's Study of the Human Animal* (1967).

The world around him

Lesser known is the fact that apart from being a zoologist extraordinaire, he was also an artist with a penchant for surrealism, and a columnist for *The Daily Mirror*. Launched in 1903 – 25 years before Morris was born – the British tabloid was originally written for women readers. Though it briefly adopted a right-wing, fascist slant, it later transformed itself into a left-leaning, working-class must-read morning paper for men. Morris later began writing for it.

Pathologically non-political and fiercely anti-establishment, he summarily rejected both the left and right parties, preferring instead to devote his mind and energy to the study and understanding of human ethology (the science of animal behaviour). In the event, he turned out to be a prolific writer with over 60 books to his credit. That said, though his books sold well, like Darwin,



The late English ethologist Desmond Morris was also a TV presenter, surrealist painter, and best-selling author. (GETTY IMAGES)

TRIBUTE [1928-2026]

DESMOND MORRIS: THE CONTROVERSIAL ZOOLOGIST

The writer of *The Naked Ape*, who died on April 19 aged 98, received both accolades and brickbats for his ‘wild’ ideas about human behaviour

Morris too angered the world of academia and the clergy.

But what people thought of him meant little to him. Besides, he was much sought after by media owners, readers, listeners and more. A media celebrity, he was also a popular host on Granada TV, and worked with the film department at the Zoological Society of London, where his films focused on animal behaviour.

Another pertinent influence on Morris was his peer David Attenborough, who turned 100 this month. The pioneering wildlife broadcaster moulded Morris's belief that complex animal behaviour, including our own, could be communicated simply and compellingly to a general audience.

Defining the self

Many have tried to categorise this giant thinker, but none as effectively as Morris himself who wrote blandly: “I am a zoologist and the naked ape is an animal. He is therefore fair game for my pen, and I refuse to avoid him any longer simply because some of his behaviour patterns are rather complex and impressive. My excuse is that, in becoming so erudite, *Homo sapiens* has remained a naked ape nevertheless; in acquiring lofty new motives, he has lost none of the earthy old ones. This is frequently a cause of some embarrassment to him, but his old impulses have been with him for millions of years, his new ones only a few thousand at the most – and there is no hope of quickly shrugging off the accumulated genetic legacy of his whole evolutionary past. He would be a far less worried and more fulfilled animal if only he would face up to this fact. Perhaps, this is where the zoologist can help.”

And help he did. Without worrying a whit about what Britain's elite, often a self-absorbed constituency, thought of him. With clinical zest he focused much of his writing on such aspects of human behaviour that found commonality with our relatives: monkeys and apes. Often this meant comparing common behavioural traits such as grooming, sleeping, fighting, mating and care of the young. Such in-your-face articulations particularly incensed the well born, stiff upper-lip gentry not accustomed to public exposés of highly personal habits, particularly explicit sexual behaviour, a virtual taboo for most Englishmen.

In his words, *Homo sapiens* or “...the hunting ape became a territorial ape. His whole sexual,

parental and social pattern began to be affected. His old wandering, fruit-plucking way of life was fading rapidly. He had now really left his forest of Eden. He was an ape with responsibilities. He began to worry about the prehistoric equivalent of washing machines and refrigerators. He began to develop the home comforts – fire, food storage, artificial shelters. But this is where we must stop for the moment, for we are moving out of the realms of biology and into the realms of culture.”

Down the years, I have read *The Naked Ape* several times over and keep returning to it and shaking my head at the sheer accuracy of Morris's predictions. In his own rapier-like words: “It is worth re-iterating here that, in this book, we are not concerned with the massive cultural explosions that followed, of which the naked ape of today is so proud – the dramatic progression that led him, in a mere half-million years, from making a fire to making a space-craft. It is an exciting story, but the naked ape is in danger of being dazzled by it all and forgetting that beneath the surface gloss he is still very much a primate. (‘An ape’s an ape, a varlet’s a varlet, though they be clad in silk or scarlet.’)”

Judging Morris today by our social norms is tantamount to misunderstanding his purpose and articulations. In his view, human beings were too clever by half and he warned that by separating ourselves from nature, we would be undermining our own future.

The writer is editor of Sanctuary Asia and founder of Sanctuary Nature Foundation.

GOREN BRIDGE

Mystery declarer

Both vulnerable.
East deals

The declarer in today's deal is not known to us. We would happily provide it, if we could, as he deserves recognition for his efforts here

East won the opening diamond lead with his ace, felling the king from South. East shifted to a low heart, ducked to West's queen. A heart to the ace and another

heart put South on play. Declarer played a spade to the ace, a spade back to his king, and another spade to East. East led a low diamond and South had to guess what to do. He could only afford one more loser. Should East have the queen of diamonds, South could discard a club on this trick and then would only have to guess the club position, assuming it was guessable. South chose to ruff the diamond. He led a club,

NORTH
♠ A 4
♥ J 6 5
♦ J 5 3 2
♣ K J 9 8

WEST
♠ 9 7
♥ Q 9 8 4
♦ Q 10 6
♣ A 10 7 3

EAST
♠ Q J 3
♥ A 10 3
♦ A 9 8 7 4
♣ Q 5

SOUTH
♠ K 10 8 6 5 2
♥ K 7 2
♦ K
♣ 6 4 2

The bidding:
EAST 1♦
SOUTH 1♠
WEST Dbl*
NORTH Redbl
All pass

Opening lead: Six of ♦

putting up dummy's king when West played low. South ruffed a diamond, felling the queen and leaving this position:
South led a low club and the defense was helpless.

Should West duck his ace, East would win and have to give dummy the jack of diamonds. The ace from West would drop East's queen and make dummy high. Beautifully done!

NORTH
♠ Void
♥ Void
♦ J
♣ J 9

WEST
♠ Void
♥ 9
♦ Void
♣ A 10

EAST
♠ Void
♥ Void
♦ 9 8
♣ Q

SOUTH
♠ 8
♥ Void
♦ Void
♣ 6 4

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has May 17 ever given us?



Henry Fredericks Jr. is an influential American blues singer-songwriter known for incorporating non-American styles in his music. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK)

Berty Ashley

1 On May 17, 1620, traveller Peter Mundy documented early, human-powered “pleasure wheels” at a fair in Philippopolis (modern-day Plovdiv, Bulgaria). He described it as a large rotating ring with dangling seats. This is the first documented reference to what familiar ride?

2 Born on May 17, 1749, Jenner was an English physician known as the father of immunology for his pioneering work in the field. He coined a certain term from the Latin word ‘vacca’ for cow. What term did he invent?

3 On May 17, 1861, Scottish scientist James Clerk Maxwell

displayed his invention to the Royal Institution in London. It was an image of a tartan ribbon taken through three filters and then recombined into one. What was this the first-ever example of?

4 On May 17, 1884, the U.S. Congress passed the first Organic Act establishing a civilian government in a region that had until then been administered by either the Army or Navy. What was this region that the U.S. had purchased from Russia for \$7.2 million?

5 Born on May 17, 1889, Dorothy Gibson was at one time the highest-paid movie actress in the world. After a holiday in Europe, she was returning to the U.S. when she became one of only 705 survivors of a famous disaster. She

later wrote and starred in a movie about her experience. What disaster was the movie about?

6 On May 17, 1900, this very popular children's novel by L. Frank Baum was first published. It is referred to as “America's best-loved homegrown fairytale”, and its movie and musical adaptations went on to become award winners as well. What is this book that is set in Kansas?

7 Born on May 17, 1942, Henry Fredericks Jr. is a highly influential American blues singer-songwriter. He is renowned for incorporating non-American musical styles into his music. This led him to adopt a stage name after dreaming about Gandhi and India. By what name is he better known, one the quizmaster

believes reflects his monumental contribution to music?

8 May 17 marks the birthday of two famous Irish singers: Enya, born in 1961, whose ‘world music’ took the ‘90s by storm, and Andrea Corr, born in 1974, who went on to become the lead singer of one of the most successful Irish bands of all time. What specific genre of music, named after an ancient tribe, did they help bring to the world stage?

9 On May 17, 1993, Intel unveiled its new processor. It was the company's fifth-generation processor, and they named it in a way to evoke a sense of a fundamental, chemical-like substance. What term came into existence?

10 On May 17, 2009, Markus Persson released his video game to the public. A sandbox game, it soon captured the interest of millions and is now one of the most popular games of all time. What game is this, which recently saw renewed popularity thanks to a movie adaptation of the same name?

11 Man should earn name, bit of conviction and fame ultimately therefore (5)

12 Removed unwanted stuff of bent conservative moving ahead (7)

13 Think right. Change course if leader is absent (7)

14 Between Angstrom and Gauss, first Maxwell, Ohm and Newton interfere (5)

15 Somehow rein lust; good for ending (9)

16 Small present, guy gets an anthropomorphic sculpture (7)

17 Animal has corona, affected by canine bite (7)

18 One day, at close son brought comrades (7)

19 Golden dish displaced at Deccan, say (7)

20 Minecraft

21 Pentium

22 Celtic

23 Taj Mahal

24 The Wizard of Oz

25 Linking of the Titanic

26 Alaska

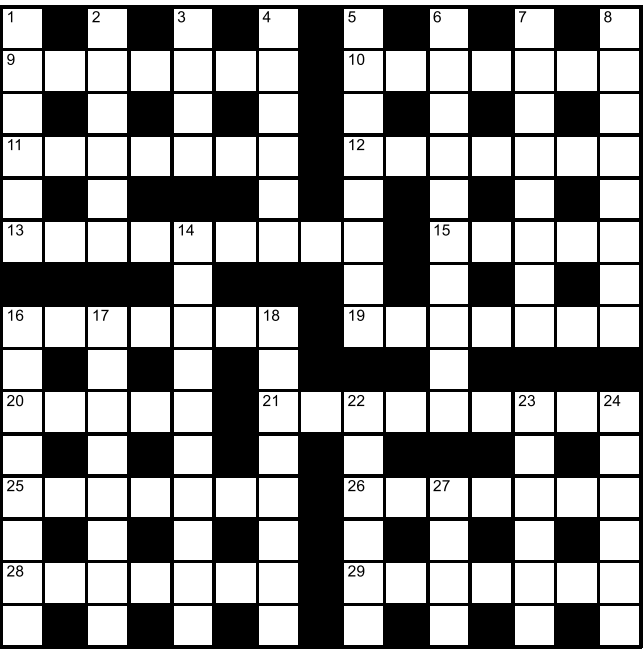
27 First colour photograph

28 Vaccine

29 Merry-go-round / Carousel

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 56 (Set by Afterdark)



Across

9 MGR and Manjula screened a relative (7)

10 One article about sanction of sportsperson (7)

11 Work in out-patient and emergency room's threatening essentially (7)

12 Imaginary line almost unchanging touching a hill (7)

13 Evaluated dates & time roughly (9)

15 Man should earn name, bit of conviction and fame ultimately therefore (5)

16 Removed unwanted stuff of bent conservative moving ahead (7)

19 Think right. Change course if leader is absent (7)

20 Between Angstrom and Gauss, first Maxwell, Ohm and Newton interfere (5)

21 Somehow rein lust; good for ending (9)

25 Small present, guy gets an anthropomorphic sculpture (7)

26 Animal has corona, affected by canine bite (7)

28 One day, at close son brought comrades (7)

29 Golden dish displaced at Deccan, say (7)

6 Contemplative, however over time gets mostly thorough (10)

7 Punishment communicated, therefore should be decapitated (8)

8 Most cheerful man retires, gets drunk (8)

14 Male worker detains mature people from board (10)

16 Order a female in exquisite clothes (8)

17 Financial cyber fraud, over millions in cash taken first (8)

18 In depth, river snakes hide at night (8)

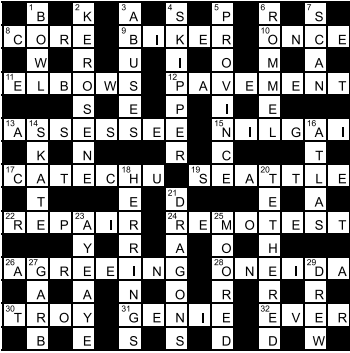
22 Intricate, crisp take to begin with in the screenplay (6)

23 Pressed to feed in parts (6)

24 Mastermind has facts on America blocking India (6)

27 Mud has carbon deposit (4)

SOLUTION NO. 55



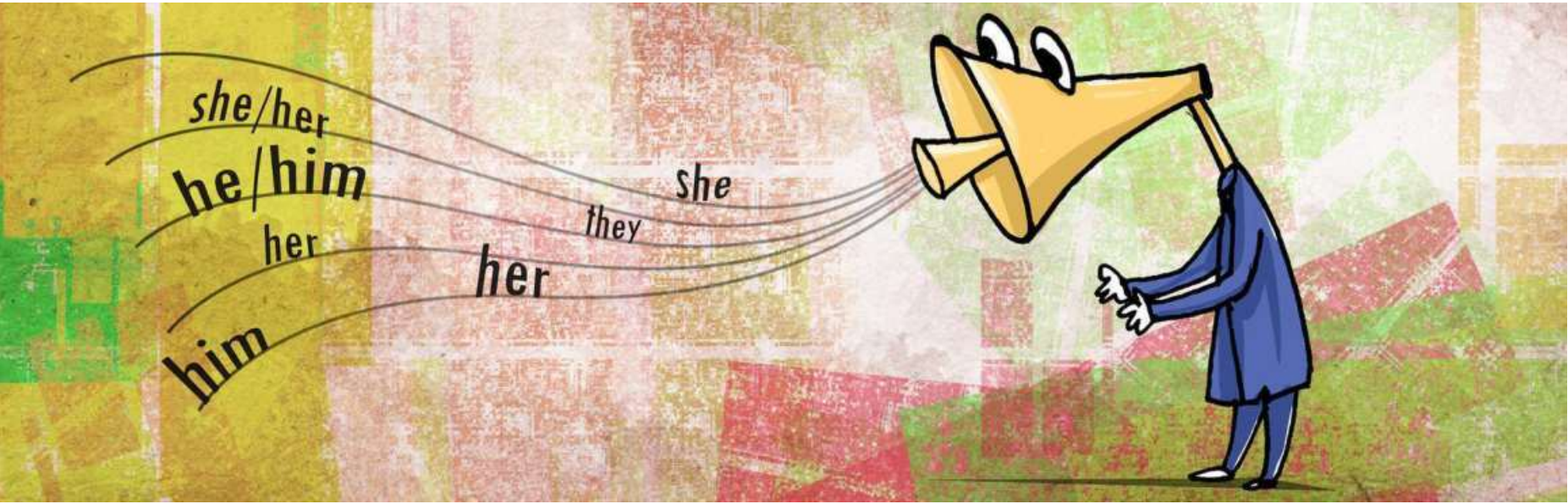


ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

Duvvuri Subbarao
subbarao@gmail.com

I first encountered pronoun protocols at the start of one of those one-week training programmes – the kind where the coffee is lukewarm, the air conditioning is set to “Arctic Tundra”, and the icebreakers are designed to make even the extreme extrovert consider a career in lighthouse keeping. We went around the room for introductions. “Name, designation, and pronouns,” the facilitator said cheerfully, as though this were as routine as stating one’s mother tongue. I was flustered. My brain, usually a reasonably efficient filing cabinet, suddenly felt like someone had tossed a flashbang into the “Identity” drawer. When my turn came, I smiled with what I hoped was calm competence but likely looked more like a man realising he had left the stove on at home. “I’m... well... I’m me,” I said. While philosophically sound and arguably the most honest thing I had said all year, it did not answer the question. A polite, heavy silence filled the room. Someone helpfully whispered, “He/him?” I seized it with the desperation of a drowning man. “Yes! That. He/him.” I sat down, feeling as though I had narrowly passed an exam I had not studied for. That moment – equal parts amusing and mildly disorienting – was my official introduction to pronoun protocols. Since then, I have come to see them less as a terrifying test of ideological purity and more as a basic social skill, akin to remembering names, or suppressing the auto response, “you too”, when a waiter tells you to enjoy your meal. At its simplest, it is just about referring to people in ways that align with how they see themselves. Pronoun protocols sound straightforward, yet like many “simple” things – such as assembling IKEA furniture or “resting” for five minutes – it has acquired layers of complexity. Some view pronoun protocols as a vital sign of gender sensitivity, a small but meaningful way of acknowledging diversity. Others, in contrast, see it as a form of unwelcome “virtue signalling” – an accessory worn to show off one’s sensitivity rather than a functional necessity. But language has never been static or simple. It evolves – awkwardly, often unevenly. That there is a pushback is itself a sign that something fundamental

A survival guide for pronoun protocols

After all, not every actor is a ‘he’, and ‘they’ has quietly been doing double duty in English for centuries anyway

is shifting. Whether you see these protocols as progress, overreach, or just another item on the long list of irritating etiquettes, they have undeniably moved from the margins to the mainstream.

Rewiring of habits
A large part of the adjustment lies in the subtle rewiring of habits we didn’t even know we had. Consider the sentence: “The actor rehearsed his part before coming on stage.” For decades, that “his” rolled off the tongue automatically. Now, we are more likely to say, “The actor rehearsed their part.” The meaning remains identical, but the language has widened its embrace. At first, pronoun protocol can feel like trying to write with your non-dominant hand – a tad unnatural, a bit slower, occasionally leading to odd-looking results. But with practice, it becomes easier. And in some cases, more precise. After all, not every actor is a “he”, and “they” has quietly been doing double duty in English for centuries anyway. Of course, the real comedy lies in the everyday practice. We have all seen the “overcorrection phase”, where a speaker becomes so determined to be inclusive that their sentence becomes a linguistic obstacle course: “They – sorry, I mean she – well, I mean, as they mentioned – oh dear.” By the time they finish the sentence, everyone has forgotten what the original point was, and we are all just staring at the floor in sympathetic secondary embarrassment. Then there are the “enthusiastic adopters” who

introduce their pronouns with such dramatic flourish – “Hello, I’m Neha, she/her, delighted to be here!” – that you half expect a round of applause to break out. And, of course, there are the “quietly bewildered”, nodding along while mentally filing away new information, hoping it will come in handy later. Through the confusion, it helps to remember that the English language has survived far more dramatic transformations than this. We have retired “thou”, embraced “you” for both singular and plural, and somehow managed to live with the absolute chaos of English spelling. Compared to the silent ‘p’ in ‘psychology’, adjusting a few pronouns seems entirely manageable. If the whole thing still feels daunting, there is always the time-tested, foolproof fallback: use names. Names are wonderfully dependable. They don’t change with context, they don’t require agreement, and they rarely spark a heated debate in the break room. “Krishna said Krishna will send the report” might sound slightly awkward, but it’s an effective way to navigate the terrain without fear of a misstep. As for me, I have made my peace with the protocol. If I ever find myself in another workshop circle, I have a plan. I’ll smile, introduce myself, state my pronouns with quiet confidence, and perhaps add, “Still learning, but improving daily.” And, I have half a mind to sign off on this piece as Duvvuri Subbarao (he/him).

The author is a former Governor of the Reserve Bank of India.

Wound to the relentless clock

Devarsh Nair R.
devarshnair123@gmail.com

One day it stopped, as the battery died. At first, it wasn’t a huge deal, but day after day, I became furious, though I could just look at my phone, laptop or tablet. What is the fuss? It’s just time, you could look at it anywhere, but that is when I discovered my obsession with time, specifically the time on the wall clock at home. The clock is more than two decades old. I remember my parents telling me to do homework on time, come home on time, eat on time, and sleep on time, as if it were their job. They were my time-tellers. It was my innocent, carefree-time era.

Disciple and lover
But now I look up at the clock two times an hour, with pending work and so many meetings and sessions scheduled for the week. It feels like I am its disciple and lover at the same time. I look up at it numerous times, like a lover who is afraid his loved one might get away if not noticed. If you don’t give it attention, it would just run away from you and never come back. Such a mischievous and toxic relationship. My parents used to look at the same clock, just like me, maybe fewer times, but now when it stopped, they did not care about it. They no longer care about their old clock friend and their precious time – no longer disciples, no longer lovers. They have now exchanged that toxic, mischievous time for my careless, innocent time. Now I have to deal with it. Maybe one day, as I grow old, I will exchange this time for my careless, innocent time and give the toxic wall clock to the next generation. And yes! I have looked at the wall clock three times while writing this.

Viney Kirpal
vineykirpal@gmail.com

A child is diagnosed with a genetic defect in the heart. The parents sit across a doctor who speaks of narrowing options and limited time. What should they do – wait, hope, or act? A 30-year-old gymnast, disciplined and fit, develops irreversible lung failure after a sudden illness. What fault is his? A young father with two small children and a non-earning spouse is told that diabetes has led to kidney failure. What does he do – resign himself to dying, or fight for time? These are not exceptional stories. They are the quiet crises of organ failure, often misunderstood and deeply feared. At the centre of this fear lies a persistent misconception: that transplantation is a desperate gamble that may or may not work, and that life after it is diseased and reduced. The truth is far more hopeful. Organ transplantation is one of modern medicine’s most life-changing surgical interventions, not because it prolongs illness, but because it restores life. When a vital organ fails, the body begins to shut down. Your heart grows weak and you take every step chasing your breath. Your kidneys fail to work and you go on dialysis. Machines and medicines can support for a while – dialysis can filter blood, oxygen can ease breathing – but these are temporary

Getting back to life

Transplantation is not a story of disease. It is a story of lives restored



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measures, not destinations. By contrast, a transplant replaces the failing organ with a healthy one, allowing the body to function again as it was meant to. Its meaning is best understood in lived experience. Before a transplant, life contracts: days revolve around hospital visits, energy is rationed, and the future feels uncertain. After a successful transplant, something remarkable happens: the ordinary returns. Children go back to school. Adults return to work. Parents resume the everyday work of caring for a family. The real story of transplantation does not end with surgery; it begins there. Unfortunately, our society is not awakened yet to what a transplant does for a human being. Recipients are often perceived, and sometimes see themselves, as permanently “sick”. This perception deserves to be

circumstance. There is also a misconception about who undergoes transplantation. It is sometimes seen as a high-end option, available only to those with means. The reality is far more sobering. The poor also get transplants when the State supports them. Middle class families exhaust savings, sell property, or turn to crowd funding to make it possible. Families don’t choose transplantation because they can afford it; they choose it because they cannot afford to lose someone. The impact extends well beyond the individual. A child who receives a new heart grows into adulthood. A parent with a transplanted kidney continues to anchor a family. A working adult returns not just to livelihood, but to dignity. A single organ can save not just the recipient, but his whole family from decline. There are challenges. Donor shortages persist, and awareness of deceased donation is uneven. Yet medicine continues to advance, improving outcomes and expanding possibilities. To understand transplantation is to know it is not an end, but a turning point – a way of reclaiming life when it seems to be slipping away. For the child, the athlete, the parent, it is not about extending a compromised existence. It is about returning to the rhythm of competing in transplant games.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

David Attenborough has brought the beauty and fragility of nature into millions of homes through his landmark documentaries. (‘David Attenborough: where the wild found its voice’; May 10) His vision emphasises conservation, biodiversity and sustainable living. His warning about climate change and ecological destruction needs to be taken seriously if we want to protect the earth for future generations.

N.S. Reddy

Attenborough’s centenary is a good moment to ask why conservation remains peripheral to policy in India. What is needed is not more awareness campaigns but stronger institutional will: independent regulators, transparent impact assessments and genuine community participation in decisions affecting forests and coastlines.

A. Myilsami

Humour sells

Rohan Chakravarty’s cartoon makes its point with an economy that most environmental writing struggles to achieve. (‘Green Humour’; May 10) Humour lowers defences and reaches readers in a way earnest advocacy rarely does. More such voices in mainstream media would serve the conservation conversation well.

Swathi Senthilkumar

A sustainable model

What stands out is not the spectacle but the restraint – the shift towards material and making over mere aesthetics. (‘Milan Design Week with Vikram Goyal’; May 10) The Shakti Design Residency’s approach, pairing international designers with Indian craft ateliers,

deserves particular attention. This is exactly the model that can sustain traditional crafts without freezing them in nostalgia.

Prajesh Paramasivan

The Nicobar story

G. Sampath’s satire lands well, but the underlying tension deserves a serious answer. (‘The Great Nicobar nuisance’; May 10) Strategic infrastructure and ecological preservation are not inherently incompatible – other nations have managed both through careful planning, independent review and phased development. The problem with Great Nicobar is the absence of a transparent process.

M. Barathi

G. Sampath, with his acerbic wit and sarcasm, has dismantled the ‘development’ defence of the Great Nicobar Island project. India has several other strategically located coastal corridors, where the proposed infrastructure project can be implemented and developed. This veritable “heaven on earth” needs to be preserved in all its pristine glory not only for its endemic wildlife and vital coastal ecosystems, but also to ensure survival of the ancient tribes inhabiting the Island.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Missing empathy

Sidin Vadukut has named something most of us recognise but rarely pause to examine. (‘My pain is better than yours’; May 10) Competitive suffering has quietly replaced empathy in everyday conversations, and social media has only accelerated the trend. Every grievance now invites a counter grievance. The fix is unglamorous: just listen.

S.M. Jeeva



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Mute the phone

Take up one task at a time, gather focus back

Indhuja Nagarajan

The final draft

An effective self-written obituary will aim to be honest

C.S. Krishnamurthy

Escape the loop

Happiness is not found in a single thing. It is fragmented, fleeting, and multiple

Arpita Kaswa

Living for oneself

The many realisations while gaining in age

Priyan R. Naik

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